

Guide 42 — Painter and Coating Worker

Controlled English working master — version 2.0

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What this job is

Painter and coating work includes more than one occupational pathway. This guide separates two related forms of work so that readers do not assume the same training, hazards, wages, or credentials apply everywhere.

Construction and maintenance painters prepare and coat walls, ceilings, buildings, bridges, machinery, equipment, and other structures. They may work indoors or outdoors, at ground level or at height, and on new construction, renovation, maintenance, or infrastructure projects.

Industrial coating and painting workers may use spray guns, rolling systems, coating machines, powder-coating equipment, or other production processes to apply protective or decorative finishes to metal, wood, plastic, transportation equipment, manufactured products, and other surfaces.

Employers may use titles such as painter, construction painter, maintenance painter, industrial painter, spray painter, powder coater, automotive painter, coating operator, paint technician, surface-preparation worker, painter-decorator, or finishing operator. The exact scope varies by employer and jurisdiction.

This guide is for career exploration and preparation. Verify current local requirements, licensing or certification rules, safety requirements, and training availability before paying for a program or accepting work.

What you may do

Depending on the pathway and employer, responsibilities can include:

- inspect surfaces and identify preparation needs;
- protect adjacent areas, equipment, fixtures, or products from overspray or contamination;
- clean, mask, scrape, sand, abrade, prime, seal, or otherwise prepare approved surfaces using employer-authorized methods;
- select or prepare coating materials according to specifications and manufacturer instructions;
- apply paint, primer, stain, varnish, lacquer, protective coatings, or related finishes using brushes, rollers, spray equipment, or production machinery;
- operate or tend coating, spraying, rolling, curing, or finishing equipment when trained and authorized;

- check color, coverage, thickness, adhesion, finish quality, defects, or production consistency;
- maintain work areas and authorized tools or equipment;
- read work orders, product labels, safety data sheets, technical data sheets, drawings, and coating specifications;
- record materials, batches, quality observations, work completion, or inspection results; and
- stop and escalate when the substrate, coating, environment, ventilation, equipment, hazardous-material status, or work-at-height condition is unsafe or outside your authorization.

Construction painters may spend more time on changing jobsites, ladders, scaffolds, exterior work, renovation, building surfaces, and customer-facing work. Industrial coating workers may spend more time in plants, paint booths, production lines, refinishing facilities, controlled coating areas, or manufacturing environments.

Work environment and physical demands

Painting and coating work can require standing, bending, kneeling, reaching, lifting, climbing, repetitive arm movement, careful visual inspection, and working in hot, cold, dusty, noisy, humid, or confined environments. Some jobs require travel or seasonal outdoor work.

BLS notes that construction and maintenance painters may work at extreme heights or in uncomfortable positions and may be exposed to falls, strains, dust, and other irritants. Industrial coating work can add machinery, compressed systems, flammable or combustible finishing materials, powders, solvents, curing processes, and production-line hazards.

A reader should evaluate the actual physical and environmental demands of a specific job. Where applicable, workers may request lawful workplace accommodations, but the feasibility of an accommodation depends on the essential functions and safety requirements of the position.

Safety comes before speed

Painting and coating can become hazardous quickly when work involves unknown old coatings, abrasive blasting, spray finishing, flammable materials, respiratory hazards, work at height, confined spaces, electrical equipment, or poorly controlled ventilation.

Do not improvise a spray booth, respirator program, ventilation system, fall-protection method, scaffold, ladder setup, confined-space procedure, abrasive-blasting process, or hazardous-coating removal process. Follow employer procedures, manufacturer instructions, safety data sheets, technical data sheets, and the regulations that apply where you work.

Stop and escalate if:

- a surface may contain lead, asbestos, or another hazardous legacy material and its status has not been assessed;
- ventilation, respiratory protection, grounding, fire protection, or required PPE is missing or unclear;

- a ladder, scaffold, anchor, guardrail, harness system, or access method appears unsafe;
- a coating or solvent is unlabeled or lacks required safety information;
- incompatible materials may be mixed or used in the same area;
- a spray area has an ignition source, ventilation failure, or uncontrolled vapor/powder accumulation;
- a confined or enclosed space has not been evaluated and authorized under the applicable procedure; or
- you have not been trained or authorized for the equipment or process.

Lead, old coatings, and hazardous surface disturbance

Old painted or coated surfaces can contain hazardous substances. In the United States, OSHA's construction lead standard, **29 CFR 1926.62**, applies to construction work where employees may be occupationally exposed to lead, including painting and decorating, renovation, scraping, sanding, spray painting with lead paint, and abrasive blasting where lead-containing coatings are present.

This does **not** mean every old coating contains lead, and it does not authorize a worker to test or remove a suspected coating on their own. It means unknown or known hazardous coatings require the employer's applicable assessment and controls before disturbance.

Version 2 therefore uses a simple boundary: **if the hazardous-material status is unknown, stop and obtain the required assessment before disturbing the surface**. Similar caution applies to asbestos-containing materials and other contaminated substrates.

Spray finishing, solvents, and fire/explosion hazards

OSHA **29 CFR 1910.107** addresses spray finishing using flammable and combustible materials. It includes requirements concerning spraying areas, ventilation and exhaust, ignition-source control, grounding and bonding, booth construction, housekeeping, residue disposal, flammable-liquid handling, powder coating, and fire protection.

A career guide cannot determine the correct booth design, ventilation rate, electrical classification, grounding method, or fire-protection system for a specific facility. Those controls belong to qualified employers, engineers, safety personnel, and applicable authorities.

Workers should know how to locate and follow the product's safety data sheet and technical data sheet and should report missing labels, damaged equipment, ventilation alarms, strong unexpected odors, leaks, spills, visible vapor or powder accumulation, and other abnormal conditions through the employer's process.

Respiratory protection

Respirators are not interchangeable with ordinary face coverings, and a cartridge that works for one hazard may be wrong for another. In the United States, OSHA **29 CFR 1910.134** establishes respiratory-protection program requirements where respirators are required, including medical evaluation, fit testing, selection, training, maintenance, and program administration.

Do not self-select a respirator or cartridge as a substitute for the employer's hazard assessment and respiratory-protection program. If a respirator is required, use only the equipment, filters/cartridges, fit-testing process, and replacement schedule approved for that work.

Skills that matter

Employers commonly value:

- careful surface inspection and preparation;
- attention to detail and finish quality;
- ability to follow written specifications and manufacturer instructions;
- basic measurement and arithmetic;
- color, texture, and defect recognition where relevant;
- safe use of brushes, rollers, spray equipment, and production machinery within authorization;
- basic material knowledge, including primers, coatings, solvents, sealers, and compatible substrates;
- quality-control awareness;
- housekeeping and contamination control;
- safe work habits around ladders, scaffolds, machinery, chemicals, and vehicles;
- communication with supervisors, customers, production teams, inspectors, and other trades; and
- reliability, punctuality, and willingness to learn employer-specific systems.

Digital skills can also help with work orders, electronic drawings, product data sheets, safety documentation, inventory, quality records, maintenance systems, or jobsite reporting. A specific software product is not universally required.

Education and entry pathways

United States — construction and maintenance painting

The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics classifies **Painters, Construction and Maintenance** under SOC **47-2141**. BLS states that painters typically learn on the job and that no formal educational credential is typically required for entry. Some specialty work may require certification or employer-specific training.

A practical entry sequence can be:

1. Learn basic measurement, surface terminology, material handling, hazard communication, and jobsite safety.
2. Review local job postings for helper, apprentice, trainee, painter, maintenance-painter, and industrial-painter roles.
3. Search public apprenticeship and workforce systems for paid or subsidized training opportunities.
4. Build supervised experience in preparation, masking, application, cleanup, quality checks, and safe equipment use.

5. Add specialty skills only when local employers require them and the training is recognized.

United States — industrial coating and painting

O*NET classifies **Coating, Painting, and Spraying Machine Setters, Operators, and Tenders** under **51-9124.00**. The work includes setting up, operating, or tending spraying or rolling machines and related coating processes. Job titles can include industrial painter, paint technician, powder coater, automotive painter, coater operator, and spray painter.

Training can be employer-based, vocational, manufacturing-oriented, automotive-refinishing-related, or specialty-coating-based depending on the setting. Do not assume a building-painting course covers machine operation, powder coating, automotive refinishing, hazardous-location controls, or industrial quality standards.

Canada — Painter and Decorator

Canada's Red Seal Program identifies **Painter and Decorator (NOC 73112)** as a designated Red Seal trade. The trade includes preparing surfaces and applying decorative and protective finishes in residential, commercial, institutional, and industrial settings.

Apprenticeship and certification are administered through provinces and territories. Requirements, compulsory-trade status, exam rules, and recognition can vary, so verify the current apprenticeship authority where you intend to work. A Red Seal pathway should be treated as a recognized interprovincial trade framework, not as a universal license that overrides local requirements.

Canada — industrial painter and coater

Government of Canada Job Bank groups industrial painters, coaters, and metal finishing process operators under **NOC 94213**. Job Bank states that this occupation usually requires a secondary school diploma or several weeks of on-the-job training.

This pathway should remain separate from Painter and Decorator apprenticeship/certification information because the work setting, machinery, and qualification expectations can differ.

Colombia

Colombia's Ministry of Labour OCUPACOL catalog includes **Pintores y empapeladores (CIUO 7131)**, with functions that include selecting and mixing paint, applying coatings to buildings and structures, applying protective primers, and performing related surface-finishing work.

SENA's public training framework includes **Pintura arquitectónica y acabados especiales** in the construction sector. Colombian readers should check current SENA/Betowa offerings, SENA's Agencia Pública de Empleo, OCUPACOL, and Ministry of Labour resources before paying for private training.

Program availability, location, admissions, duration, and credential type can change. A listing in SENA's framework does not guarantee that a specific cohort is open today.

Latin America and the Caribbean

Training and credential systems differ by country. OIT/Cinterfor documents vocational-training institutions and competency systems across the region. Examples include SENA in Colombia, SENCE in Chile, INTECAP in Guatemala, INFOTEP in the Dominican Republic, INEFOP in Uruguay, INA in Costa Rica, and other national institutions.

Chile's SENCE has offered construction training that includes painting and varnishing. Use these public systems as current-program locators rather than assuming that one country's credential transfers automatically to another.

Free-first and low-cost learning strategy

Do not assume an expensive private certificate is the first step. A safer sequence is:

1. Review 15–20 real local job postings for the pathway you want.
2. Record recurring requirements for experience, safety cards, apprenticeship, equipment, coatings, shifts, and credentials.
3. Search public vocational systems, apprenticeship programs, workforce agencies, unions where applicable, and employer-paid training.
4. Learn basic surface terminology, measurement, coating-system concepts, hazard communication, and quality-control principles using public or employer-approved resources.
5. Complete hands-on practice only under safe, authorized conditions with the required supervision and equipment.
6. Consider private training only after verifying total cost, refund terms, employer recognition, and whether the credential appears repeatedly in real job postings.

Never use unsupervised hazardous practice as a substitute for formal safety or equipment training.

Apprenticeships and work-based learning

United States

BLS directs readers to the U.S. Department of Labor's apprenticeship system for painter apprenticeship information. Registered Apprenticeship opportunities depend on employer, union/industry arrangements, location, and current openings.

Useful entry titles can include painter helper, apprentice painter, maintenance helper, industrial-painter trainee, coating-line trainee, paint-preparation worker, or production-finisher worker.

Canada

Painter and Decorator is a Red Seal trade. Apprenticeship is administered through provincial and territorial systems. Check the relevant apprenticeship authority for current technical-training, hours, exam, certification, and employer-registration rules.

Colombia and Latin America

Public vocational institutions can provide technical, complementary, or employment-linked training. Availability can be cohort-based and eligibility can vary. Start with the national public institution and verify current enrollment before spending money elsewhere.

Funding and employer support

Funding is never guaranteed. Depending on jurisdiction and eligibility, possible support can include public workforce training, apprenticeship-related assistance, employer-paid training, tuition reimbursement, PPE or tool allowances, union/industry training, or local employment programs.

Ask an employer whether it offers:

- paid onboarding;
- trainee or apprenticeship positions;
- employer-provided PPE and fit testing where required;
- tool or equipment allowances;
- specialty-coating or manufacturer training;
- certification or exam reimbursement;
- cross-training into inspection, quality, maintenance, estimating, or supervision; and
- internal promotion pathways.

Get any reimbursement, retention, repayment, or tool-charge terms in writing before spending money.

Income and job outlook

United States — construction and maintenance painters

BLS reports for **Painters, Construction and Maintenance**:

- **Median annual wage, May 2024: \$48,660**
- **Median hourly wage: \$23.40**
- **Employment in 2024: about 342,200**
- **Projected growth, 2024–2034: 4%**
- **Projected openings: about 28,100 per year on average**

These are national statistics and are not guaranteed starting wages. Pay varies by location, employer, specialty, union status, experience, overtime, and work setting.

United States — industrial coating and painting

O*NET reports for **51-9124.00**:

- **Median wage, 2025: \$23.20/hour / \$48,250/year**
- **Employment in 2024: about 165,500**
- **Projected growth, 2024–2034: 1% to 2%**

- **Projected openings displayed by O*NET: about 15,800**

Do not blend these numbers with the construction-painter statistics. They describe a different occupational classification.

Canada — Painter and Decorator

Government of Canada Job Bank reports national Painter and Decorator wages, updated November 19, 2025, of approximately:

- **CAD \$20.00/hour low**
- **CAD \$28.00/hour median**
- **CAD \$40.99/hour high**

Canada — industrial painters and coaters

Government of Canada Job Bank reports national wages of approximately:

- **CAD \$18.00/hour low**
- **CAD \$24.61/hour median**
- **CAD \$36.00/hour high**

Local rates can differ substantially. Use Job Bank's province, territory, and regional filters before making relocation or training decisions.

Colombia

SENA's public employment system has recently listed construction-painter vacancies, but individual vacancy salaries are local snapshots rather than national occupational wage statistics. Use current SENA Agencia Pública de Empleo and Ministry of Labour information for present local demand, and do not treat one posting as a guaranteed market rate.

A practical 12-week starter plan

Weeks 1–2: Choose your target pathway: construction/maintenance painting or industrial coating. Review 15–20 local job postings and record recurring requirements.

Weeks 3–4: Learn basic measurement, surface types, coating-system terminology, primer/topcoat concepts, labels, SDS/TDS use, housekeeping, and quality language.

Weeks 5–6: Complete employer-approved or public safety learning relevant to your setting: hazard communication, PPE, ladders/scaffolds/fall prevention, respiratory hazards, and chemical handling. Do not perform regulated tasks merely because you completed an online course.

Weeks 7–8: Under supervision, practice low-risk preparation, masking, brush/roller technique, cleanup, material tracking, and finish inspection using approved materials and surfaces.

Weeks 9–10: If your target is industrial coating, learn the employer's production flow, quality checks, equipment authorization process, ventilation/booth rules, lockout boundaries, and defect terminology. Do not operate equipment until trained and authorized.

Weeks 11–12: Apply for helper, trainee, apprentice, or entry roles. Compare public and employer-paid training against any private program before enrolling.

Building experience without already having the title

Transferable experience can come from:

- building maintenance;
- construction labor or trade-helper work;
- facilities or property maintenance;
- automotive body/refinishing support;
- manufacturing or production;
- warehouse and materials handling;
- cleaning and surface-preparation work;
- marine, industrial, or infrastructure support roles; or
- supervised vocational or community projects.

Describe experience accurately. Useful evidence can include safe preparation, low rework, consistent finish quality, reliable attendance, correct material handling, accurate records, housekeeping, customer communication, or successful completion of supervised training.

Do not claim certified applicator, Red Seal, licensed painter, industrial blaster, confined-space entrant, respirator-qualified worker, automotive refinisher, inspector, or equipment-operator status unless you actually hold the required qualification or authorization.

Advancement

Possible progression can include experienced painter, journey-level painter/decorator, industrial painter, coating operator, specialty applicator, crew lead, foreperson, finishing-line lead, quality technician, coating inspector, estimator, supervisor, facilities painter, maintenance technician, or self-employment where legally permitted.

Specialty work may require additional training in areas such as high-performance protective coatings, automotive refinishing, corrosion control, powder coating, industrial blasting, fireproofing, waterproofing, bridge/marine work, inspection, or hazardous-material controls. Verify the actual employer and jurisdiction requirements before paying for specialty credentials.

Using AI responsibly in this work

AI tools may help explain general terminology, generate practice interview questions, summarize non-sensitive study notes, or organize a training checklist. They must not replace:

- safety data sheets or technical data sheets;
- exposure assessments;

- respirator selection or fit testing;
- ventilation or spray-booth engineering;
- fall-protection plans;
- confined-space procedures;
- hazardous-material determinations;
- coating specifications;
- manufacturer mixing/application limits;
- inspection acceptance criteria; or
- employer-approved work instructions.

Do not paste proprietary formulas, customer information, protected drawings, internal incident details, credentials, pricing, or confidential specifications into public AI services without authorization.

Verify AI-generated ratios, compatibility claims, surface-preparation advice, cure times, film-thickness values, environmental limits, safety recommendations, and citations against approved source documents before using them.

Cybersecurity and privacy basics

Modern contractors and manufacturers may use cloud work orders, digital SDS libraries, quality systems, coating-specification databases, estimating tools, customer portals, and mobile jobsite apps. Follow employer rules for:

- passwords and multifactor authentication;
- approved devices and file-sharing locations;
- suspicious links and attachments;
- customer addresses and contact information;
- proprietary coating specifications and pricing;
- incident and safety records;
- photos taken at customer or industrial sites; and
- use of personal devices or public AI tools.

Verify unusual requests for bank changes, urgent payments, credential resets, or confidential file transfers through an approved second channel.

Avoid scams and weak training offers

Be cautious when a training provider, recruiter, or employer:

- guarantees a job, apprenticeship, license, or specific salary;
- says a private certificate is legally required without showing the official rule;
- pressures you to pay immediately;
- will not disclose total tuition, equipment costs, refund rules, or credential recognition;
- claims that a short online class alone authorizes hazardous spray, blasting, respiratory, lead, scaffold, or confined-space work;

- asks you to pay for a job offer or equipment shipment using gift cards, cryptocurrency, or unusual payment methods; or
- requests sensitive identity or banking information before you can independently verify the organization.

Use official government, apprenticeship, employer, union/industry, or recognized public-training sources to verify claims.

When to pause before spending money

Pause before paying when:

- local employers do not repeatedly request the credential;
- the provider cannot explain whether the course applies to construction painting, industrial coating, automotive refinishing, or another specialty;
- public or employer-paid training may cover the same skill;
- you have not verified whether a credential is recognized in your jurisdiction;
- the provider cannot disclose total cost and refund terms in writing;
- the course encourages hazardous practice without supervised controls; or
- financing would create debt you cannot comfortably repay.

Current sources

Official/public sources:

- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics — Painters, Construction and Maintenance: <https://www.bls.gov/ooh/construction-and-extraction/painters-construction-and-maintenance.htm>
- O*NET OnLine — Coating, Painting, and Spraying Machine Setters, Operators, and Tenders (51-9124.00): <https://www.onetonline.org/link/details/51-9124.00>
- OSHA — 29 CFR 1910.107, Spray finishing using flammable and combustible materials: <https://www.osha.gov/laws-regs/regulations/standardnumber/1910/1910.107>
- OSHA — 29 CFR 1926.62, Lead: <https://www.osha.gov/laws-regs/regulations/standardnumber/1926/1926.62>
- OSHA — 29 CFR 1910.134, Respiratory protection: <https://www.osha.gov/laws-regs/regulations/standardnumber/1910/1910.134>
- Red Seal Program — Painter and Decorator: <https://red-seal.ca/eng/trades/painter-decorator.shtml>
- Red Seal Occupational Standard — Painter and Decorator: <https://red-seal.ca/eng/trades/paintdeco/overview.shtml>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Painters and decorators wages: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/wagereport/occupation/6523>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Industrial painters/coaters wages: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/wagereport/occupation/18915>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Industrial painter labour-market summary: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/summary-occupation/18980/ca>

- Colombia Ministry of Labour OCUPACOL — Pintores y empapeladores:
<https://ocupacol.mintrabajo.gov.co/Profile/OccupationalProfile/71310>
- SENA — training framework including Pintura arquitectónica y acabados especiales:
https://normograma.sena.edu.co/compilacion/docs/circular_sena_0021_2025.htm
- SENA — architectural-painting training example:
<https://www.sena.edu.co/es-co/Noticias/Paginas/noticia.aspx?IdNoticia=7988>
- OIT/Cinterfor — institutional vocational-training network:
<https://www.oitcinterfor.org/red-institucional>
- OIT/Cinterfor — Central America, Panama, Dominican Republic and Haiti vocational-training network: <https://www.oitcinterfor.org/recursos/redIFP>
- Chile SENCE — construction training including painting and varnishing:
<https://sence.gob.cl/node/5146>

Important limitations

This guide provides general educational and career-navigation information. It is not legal advice, occupational-health advice, medical advice, environmental-compliance advice, engineering advice, a licensing determination, or a substitute for employer training or competent supervision.

Training availability, wages, occupational classifications, certification rules, licensing requirements, safety standards, and funding can change. Verify the current rule and local source before acting.

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